

THE STRATUM METHOD

Lesson 5 · Strata 05 · Resource 3 of 3

FOUR SIGNS

the want or need

ISN'T PRECISE ENOUGH

*A field guide organized by session stage —
one failure pattern per stage of the Dramaturg's Method.*



Four Signs the Want or Need Isn't Precise Enough

The Dramaturg's Method fails in the same four places, every time — one per stage. This resource closes the sequence that opened with Resource 1's definitions and Resource 2's technique: it names each failure by the stage that produces it, shows what it sounds like when it happens, and shows the question that corrects it.

IDENTIFY
THE WANT
STAGE 1

UNCOVER
THE NEED
STAGE 2

VERIFY THE
OPPOSITION
STAGE 3

WRITE THE
SENTENCE
STAGE 4



SIGN 1 · STAGE 1

The Want Is Still a Goal

The test: could this be achieved once, completely, and be finished? If yes, you have stopped at the external goal and haven't pushed to the psychological strategy underneath it yet.

WEAK

"Her want is to defeat the Capitol." Recorded as the deliverable — but this is the plot goal from Lesson 1's premise, not a want. It finishes when the war ends.

STRONG

"If the Capitol fell tomorrow, would she stop doing what she does? What is she still trying to prove, to herself, regardless of who wins?"

2

SIGN 2 · STAGE 2

The Need Is Still a Wish

The test: could this sentence be pasted onto almost any character in any story without becoming false? If yes, it's a desirable state, not a need — it isn't built from this character's specific lie.

WEAK

"She needs to be happy." "He needs closure." Both sound true and explain nothing — neither references the lie they're supposed to unravel.

STRONG

"What would have to be true about her, specifically, for the lie to be wrong? Not what would feel good — what would falsify it?"

3

SIGN 3 · STAGE 3

The Opposition Isn't Structural

The test: walk the want and the need through one real instance from Lesson 1. If the character could, in that exact moment, act on the want and still receive the need, the two aren't actually opposed yet — they're just different.

WEAK

Student argues Katniss could keep protecting everyone and also learn to trust others — "at the same time, eventually." No moment forces a choice between them.

STRONG

"In this instance — volunteering for Prim — does choosing the want close off the need, or could she have had both? Show me the moment where taking one costs her the other."

4

SIGN 4 · STAGE 4

The Sentence Needs a Second Sentence

The test: read the conflict sentence aloud. If it needs a qualifier, an exception, or a second sentence to make sense, the want or the need is still loose — the compression is what exposes the imprecision.

WEAK

"Pursuing her want makes her need harder to get, mostly, in certain situations, unless she's with Peeta." The hedges are doing the work the sentence should be doing alone.

STRONG

The coach refuses the sentence as written and sends the student back to whichever stage produced the loose term — never softens the test to accept the hedge.

PASSING EXAMPLE — THE FULL RUN

Katniss, All Four Stages Held

Want: to guarantee, through constant vigilance, that no one she loves is ever helpless because she failed them — a standing condition, not an event, so Stage 1 holds. Need: to trust others enough to be protected herself — falsifies the lie directly, so Stage 2 holds. Instance: volunteering for Prim forecloses the need in that exact moment, so Stage 3 holds. Sentence: "Pursuing her guarantee that no one she loves will be helpless makes it impossible for her to receive proof that she is safe to need someone, because every act of control confirms the belief that she is the only protection available" — no hedge required, so Stage 4 holds.

NEXT — LESSON 6

Five layers are complete: behavior, belief, wound, lie, and now the want-need engine built on top of them. Lesson 6 asks what your character fears losing if the need is ever met, and what they've stopped letting themselves desire because of it.